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Ministry Resources Hub

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Lesson 1. Intimacy with God

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Lesson 1. Intimacy with God

I. WHAT IS INTIMACY WITH GOD?

- A. Definition: Intimacy with God is about a close, personal relationship with Him—knowing His character, hearing His voice, and walking in His ways.
- B. Jesus' Example: Jesus frequently withdrew to quiet places to pray and spend time with the Father (Luke 5:16). This modeled the importance of a deep, ongoing connection with God.

II. THREE DIMENSIONS OF INTIMACY (UP, IN, OUT)

A. **Up: Relationship with the Father**

Focus on prayer, worship, and studying the Word. Intimacy grows as we align our desires with God's will.

Exercise: Set aside time each day for personal worship, prayer, and listening to God. Create a worship playlist that draws your focus to God's character.

B. **In: Community with Believers**

Intimacy with God is also nurtured in community. Fellowship with other believers helps keep our faith vibrant.

C. **Out: Mission to the World**

Part of intimacy with God is loving what He loves—being on mission to reach others. Engaging in God's mission is an expression (action of worship) of our relationship with Him.

III. INTIMACY AS SEEN IN COVENANT AND KINGDOM

A. Covenant = Relationship (Genesis, Abraham, Moses, Jesus)

1. Three essential elements of Covenant.

- The Fatherhood of God
- Identity
- Obedience

B. Kingdom = Responsibility (God, Judges, David, Jesus)

1. Three essential elements of Kingdom

- King
- Authority
- Power

IV. SPIRITUAL DISCIPLINES FOR GROWING IN INTIMACY

A. **Prayer and Meditation:** Use prayer not only to present requests but also to listen to God. Meditate on His Word.

Prayer Journaling: Write down your prayers and anything you sense God is speaking to you. Reflect on answered prayers as a reminder of His faithfulness.

B. **Fasting:** Fasting helps draw us closer to God by denying ourselves to seek Him more fully. It helps increase spiritual sensitivity.

Exercise: Choose a day to fast from food or an activity that often distracts you from God. Spend that time in focused prayer and Bible reading.

C. **Abiding in God's Word:** Jesus says, "If you remain in me and my words remain in you, ask whatever you wish, and it will be done for you" (John 15:7). Make Bible reading a daily discipline.

Exercise: Memorize a passage each week, such as John 15:1-11, to internalize God's promises.

V. PRACTICAL ACTIVITIES FOR DEEPENING INTIMACY

A. **Quiet Retreats:** Take a day or a few hours each month for personal retreat—a time to step away from routine and focus solely on God.

B. **Meditative Bible Reading:** Read Scripture slowly, reflecting on what it reveals about God's character, promises, and desires. This is different from studying for

knowledge—it's about letting the Word draw you closer to God. Read a passage slowly, meditate, pray over it, and rest in God's presence.

- C. **Memorizing Scripture** helps internalize God's Word, making it readily available for meditation throughout the day. It also helps believers resist temptation, as Jesus did when He quoted Scripture during His temptation in the wilderness (Matthew 4:1-11).

Practical Tips for Memorization: Start with key verses that emphasize God's love, promises, and character. Write them down, repeat them regularly, and use them in prayer.

- D. **Daily Gratitude Practice:** End each day by listing three things you are grateful for and thanking God for them.

VI. WORSHIP AS A PATHWAY TO INTIMACY

- A. **Private and Corporate Worship:** Worship is a powerful way to draw near to God. Private worship involves singing, playing music, or simply expressing love to God through words or art. Corporate worship brings believers together to experience God's presence collectively, fostering a sense of unity and shared intimacy with God.

B. **Practical Application:**

1. Make worship a daily habit, whether through singing, listening to worship music, or reading Psalms of praise.
2. Participate actively in corporate worship, focusing on God's presence and expressing love for Him.

- C. **Worship as a Lifestyle:** True worship goes beyond music and church services—it's about offering every part of your life to God (Romans 12:1). This includes work, relationships, and daily activities, all done with an attitude of love and surrender to God.

VII. INTIMACY THROUGH OBEDIENCE

- A. **Obedience Brings Closeness:** Jesus says, "If you love me, keep my commands" (John 14:15). We grow in intimacy when we choose to obey God, even when it's difficult.

Exercise: Identify one command from Scripture that you find challenging and commit to obeying it, asking God for strength.

VIII. BARRIERS TO INTIMACY

A. **Unconfessed Sin:** Sin creates a barrier between us and God (Isaiah 59:2).

Confession restores fellowship.

Exercise: Spend time in confession and repentance. Write down anything the Holy Spirit brings to mind, confess it, and receive God's forgiveness.

B. **Distractions:** Identify what distracts you from spending time with God. Create a strategy to minimize these distractions.

Exercise: Identify one major distraction and set boundaries to eliminate or limit it.

IX. IMPACT OF INTIMACY ON DISCIPLESHIP

A. **Fuel for Ministry:** Intimacy with God provides the spiritual strength and motivation to disciple others.

B. **Visible Fruit:** A close walk with God results in evident spiritual fruit—love, joy, peace, patience (Galatians 5:22-23)—which is attractive to others.

C. **Reflecting God's Heart:** As we grow closer to God, our heart begins to align with His heart for people. This alignment drives us to reach out to others and disciple them.

This lesson was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org).

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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